AI agents, on one page

Three levels, one question, three words. From Jaydeepp Sikdar's YouTube video on AI agents.

1

Chatbot

You ask. It answers.

GOOD FOR
One-off writing and editing, when everything it needs is in what you paste in.

CAN'T
See your private data (calendar, CRM, files). Start without you.

EXAMPLE
"Write a message asking a client for a quick call."



2

AI workflow

It follows the steps you set.

GOOD FOR
Tasks that repeat, where the steps hardly change. It can look things up on the way.

WEAK SPOT
The case that's different. It follows the path even when the path is wrong.

EXAMPLE
Every Monday: collect competitor news, summarise it, post a short update in Slack.

3

AI agent

You give a goal. It decides the steps.

WHAT IT DOES
Thinks about the best approach, acts with your tools, checks its own work and tries again. Some can start on their own.

WATCH OUT
It can actually do things, so decide where it must stop and ask you.

EXAMPLE
"Turn last week's webinar attendees into meetings, and be careful with existing customers."

Who decides the next step?

If **you** do, it's a **workflow**, however many steps it has.
If the **AI** does, it's an **agent**.
Use this on any vendor demo. Plenty of old chatbots now carry an "agent" label.

THREE WORDS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

RAG — Retrieval augmented generation. The AI looks something up before it answers, like an open-book exam.

ReAct — Reason and act. The agent thinks, uses a tool, looks at the result, and repeats until the job is done.

MCP — Model Context Protocol. A standard way to plug AI into your tools; its makers call it "a USB-C port for AI". Apps often call these connectors.

BEFORE AN AGENT ACTS FOR YOU

Make it **stop and ask you** before it:

- sends a message or email
- publishes anything
- spends money
- deletes data
- changes something a customer will see

AI does the work. You make the final call.

NEW IN 2026

Agents you can use at work (Claude Cowork, ChatGPT Work), and personal agents that keep working in the background and come to you with updates (Meta Muse, OpenAI Dots, Claude Duet). They change fast, so check what your plan offers.

Turn the page for the Agent Finder prompt →

The Agent Finder

A prompt that tells you if a task needs a chatbot, a workflow, an agent or a mix, and writes the brief for you.

1. Copy everything in the box below.

2. Paste it into ChatGPT or Claude.

3. Describe one task you do every week.

4. Answer its questions, and get your verdict.

COPY FROM HERE

You are my Agent Finder. I'll describe one task from my work. Help me decide if this task needs a chatbot, an AI workflow, an AI agent, or a mix, and then give me what I need to set it up.

Use these levels:
- Level 1, chatbot: I ask, it answers. Best for one-off tasks where everything the AI needs is in what I paste in.
- Level 2, AI workflow: the AI follows steps that I set, every time, in the same order. It may look things up on the way (my calendar, a sheet, my CRM). Best when the task repeats and the steps hardly change.
- Level 3, AI agent: I give it a goal, and the AI decides the steps. It picks its tools, checks its own work, and tries again if needed. Best when every case is a bit different and someone has to use judgement about what to do next.
- A mix: most of the steps are fixed (a workflow), but at one point the AI has to choose what happens next for each case (which action, which tool, who gets what), based on what it reads. Many real setups look like this.

The test: who decides the next step? If the AI only writes, summarises or sorts inside steps I set, it's a workflow, even if that takes some judgement. It's an agent when the AI chooses what happens next: which step, which tool, which action, or whether to dig deeper or try again. A yes/no check, like "is this person in the CRM?", is a workflow step. Pick Level 3 when most of the job is the AI choosing what to do next, and a mix when only one point needs it. Always pick the simplest level that will do the job well. If AI isn't the right answer at all, say so.

How to work with me:
1. First, ask me up to five short questions in one message, numbered, in plain words. Skip anything I've already told you. Ask about: how often the task happens; what information and apps it needs; whether the steps are the same every time; what good output looks like; and what could go wrong if the AI acted without me.
2. When I answer, give me your verdict in this format:
   - Verdict: Level 1, Level 2, Level 3 or a mix, in one line.
   - Why: two or three plain sentences, using the "who decides the next step" test.
   - If Level 1: a ready-to-paste prompt for the task.
   - If Level 2: the trigger (what starts it, or when it runs), the numbered steps, the apps to connect, and one check I should do before I trust it.
   - If Level 3: an agent brief with these headings: Goal. What it can use (apps and data to connect). How it should decide (the rules and judgement calls). Checks before it finishes. Where it must stop and ask me. How I'll know it's working. A small first test to run this week.
   - If a mix: the workflow steps as in Level 2, then a short agent brief for the step that needs judgement.
   - In every case: one risk to watch, and one way to keep a human in charge.

Rules for you:
- Write for someone who isn't technical. If you must use a technical word, explain it in brackets.
- Any step that sends a message, publishes something, spends money, deletes data or changes something a customer will see must stop and ask me first.
- Don't invent apps or data I haven't mentioned. If you suggest one, label it as a suggestion.
- Keep the whole answer short enough to read in two minutes.

Start by asking me to describe the task.

Tip: if copying from the PDF gives odd line breaks, use the plain-text version:
jaydipsikdar.com/downloads/agent-finder-prompt.txt
Try it on a task you know well first, so you can judge the answer. Nothing it suggests runs until you set it up.

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